



Reveal and conceal This strapless black gown uses a peek-a-boo bodice treatment, further emphasizing the décolletage. Made of silk taffeta, the full skirt reveals a section of light pink underskirt below a see-through net panel.



1953

Clover gown Charles James created his Four-Leaf Clover gown for Mrs William Randolph Hearst, Jr to wear to the Eisenhower Inaugural Ball. His background in architecture and his tendency towards sculptural, highly controlled silhouettes are evident here.



1954

Custom couture Christian Dior designed this gown, *La Ligne Muguet*, based on his runway model *Belle de Nuit* for socialite Gloria Guinness. Intricate handwork, including beading, metallic embroidery, and ribbon work, emphasizes the luxury of his couture work.



Flounces and bustles Victor Stiebel, a South African-born British designer, referenced historical elements with this gown. The blue and white striped silk taffeta underskirt includes a knee-high flounce and the draped overskirt has a slight bustle.



1957

Stripes Frank Usher, an important ready-to-wear design firm in the UK during the 1950s, created this extravagant strapless evening gown in 1957. Horizontal stripes in a delicate pink accentuate the high-waisted bodice and daring décolletage.

ACCESSORIES



Women who could afford to buy expensive couture gowns usually had real jewels – including diamonds, emeralds, and rubies – to go with them. Pearls were popular too, either in single strands, or combined with other elements in statement pieces such as the 1959 pearl necklace and earrings seen here. For those without real gems, there was costume jewellery. Manufacturers such as Vendôme created striking costume jewellery using artificial stones and imitation metals. The bracelet shown above is embedded with rhinestones in emerald green, ruby red, and clear crystal.